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FUNCTIONAL EDUCATION FOR VALUE RE-ORIENTATION AND NATIONAL DEVELOPMENT IN NIGERIA

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Abstract

The increasing decline in moral values, civic responsibility, and national unity in Nigeria has raised critical concerns about the role of education in reversing these negative trends. These negative trends are coming from the arising incidents of moral decadence, corruption, examination malpractice, ritual killings, cybercrime and the resent prevalent cases of Fulani Herdsmen, Boko Haram and insurgency, that have claimed the lives of the innocent ones which have become rampant, indicating a major breakdown in the nation's value systems. The paper is focused on functional education- for value re-orientation and national development in Nigeria. It is set to consider the need for value reorientation in Nigeria, education as a transformative tool for value

reorientation, education for poverty eradication and National Development. Therefore, education in Nigeria was expected to provide technical knowledge, and vocational skills for preparing individuals for useful living through re-orientation of value in the society. However, the Nigerian problem is the failure of Nigerian education system to produce right values and right priorities that will provoke national development. It was recommended among others that educational curriculum should be reviewed to address National values across the subjects. It was, therefore, concluded that when properly implemented, education can instill core values and end enhance National development.

Keywords: Education, Eradication, development, national-value, National-reorientation.

Introduction

Nigeria is a rich country endowed with diversified natural resources such as oil and gas; and vast land for agricultural cultivation and infrastructural developments. It also had moral values that directed the course of her history which predates to the 17th century when oil trade, was popular particularly with the Portuguese and the people that habited the coastal regions and the hinterlands (Amie-Ogan, 2016). Children had value-oriented education for individual and societal benefits. These made the young adults in business and other ventures to be regarded as trustworthy citizens as a result of values that molded their character in the different stages of their development.

One of the most important problems confronting philosophers and educators is the problem of values, generally known as axiology. Value is the importance attached to objects, institutions, and industries in the society. Value according to Bolarin (2005) is the worth, merit or esteem given to a person or an object or an idea. Values influence people's behavior and serve as a yardstick for evaluating the actions of other people in the society. It cumulatively formed lasting beliefs or ideas shared by members of a culture about what is good or bad, and desirable or undesirable. Parents have a duty to look after children, protect them, educate them, discipline them, clothe them and bring them up; while children on their part must obey their parents or older members of the family by practicing what they are told at home or in the fields, to respect those who are older, to be humble in the presence of their parents or older people (Mbiti in Osaat, 2011).

In such societies, they are handed down from one generation to another by word and action. In the domain of education, values are paramount, for they are tightly bound to the general idea of education and the operation of schools. Education must be something worthwhile with value implication. Cultural values are those collective conceptions of things that are considered good, desirable and proper in people's culture (Schaefer, 2003) in Okolo 2011). The negative values include bribery and corruption, human trafficking, kidnapping, economic sabotage, tribal and religious division, ritual killing, rape, robbery, terrorism, cultism, wanton destruction of government and individual property in the society.

The acquisition of good values will enable the individual to determine how reasonable, right or wrong, true or appropriate his actions, attitude as well as relationship with others are. Therefore, if all learning and training cannot make one of good value, then education is a failure. Education

is expected to be a transmitter of worthwhile values. Values are conceived of in term of what is accepted in any social system. Value is more or less a consistent body of standards which gives meaning or direction to an attitude identified among others as compassion, curtesy, honest, integrity, responsibility, trustworthiness and truthfulness. The value system of each society emanates from the environment and how the individual in such environment uses that environment. It is also transferred to up-coming generations of the environment as they act on the environment.

In Nigeria, values emanated from the family. The family does not only consist of the nucleus and extended families, but neighbors also who took interest in correcting wrong behavior of a child. This was because the child was seen as everybody's child and not specifically for his parents to train for societal sanity and development. Most of the basic family values were imbibed by children through observation and participation and not necessarily under strict tutelage. Such values are discipline, honesty, empathy, sympathy, dignity of labour, selfless service, loyalty, hospitality indiscrimination, tolerance and forbearance. Osaat (2011) in giving credence stressed truth, hospitality, honesty, generosity, consideration for others, hard work, and friendliness as core family values. Mgbiti in Osaat (2011) further reiterated on the impact of home values on its members thus; it is held to be morally evil to deny hospitality even to a stranger.

Nigeria in recent times is under a siege of upheavals underpinned by poor governance, kidnapping, terrorism, oil bunkering, illegal mining of solid minerals, vandalisation of oil pipelines and electric cables, child trafficking, Fulani herdsman attacks and other corrupt practices that are inimical to the growth and stability of the nation. In spite of the crime fighting agencies through the Nigerian Police, the Nigerian Prisons service, the Economic Financial Crime Commission, Independent Corrupt Practices Commission and Code of Bureau; Criminal acts, economic sabotage, and astronomical growth rates of poverty pervade and persist in the nation, thus frustrating government's efforts to entrench laudable social, political and economic programs for the good of her citizenry. These catalogue of ineffectiveness in the implementation of programs to alleviate the suffering of the masses may not be exonerated from lost values and a lack of value system directing individuals and the nation.

The Need for Value Reorientation in Nigeria

Nigeria is experiencing a deepening crisis of values, evident in the widespread erosion of ethical standards across all strata of society. This moral degeneration has become a fundamental barrier to sustainable development, peaceful coexistence and reveals the urgency for value reorientation. Example of such value degeneration are:

1. weakness of families by poor parenting where the school becomes a critical substitute for value transmission by providing consistent, structured moral education regardless of learners' home backgrounds (Iwuanyanwu, 2021);
2. Incidents of sexual immorality, including early pregnancies most especially among youths in our societies. To curb this, Offorma, (2020) opined that the Nigerian curriculum must go

beyond content delivery to encompass the deliberate inculcation of ethical reasoning and moral sensitivity.

3. Issues such as cultism, drug abuse, armed robbery, kidnapping, and general indiscipline have become a way of socialization among our youths such that if you are not part of the group, consequently you termed not to be a social person. The suggested educational approach to arrest this ugly situation, according to Offorma (2020), is that education must be restructured to promote civic responsibility, social cohesion and peace education.
4. Igbuzor, (2019), agreement observed that there is high level of national disintegration which should attract the attention of education stakeholders to restructure curriculum in schools so as to promote intercultural understanding, religious tolerance, and the spirit of unity in diversity.
5. Furthermore, Igbuzor, (2019) also stated that there is proliferation of fraudulent practices such as internet scams, money rituals, and Ponzi schemes as a result of loss of empathy, discipline, and self-control among youth which call for curricula that integrate emotional intelligence, peace education, conflict resolution, and civic responsibility;
6. Erosion of Respect for Authority and Elders is another value challenge in most parts of the country which calls for educational curriculum strategies that promote character education;
7. Normalization of Dishonesty and Cheating which has painfully become part of indecent living demands for curriculum that promotes integrity, honesty, and accountability—reinforced through classroom activities, stories, role plays, and reward systems—is essential to correct this perception;
8. Gender-Based Violence and Discrimination: Gender-based violence, child marriages and gender discrimination is common in many communities. These call for a functional educational design that promote equality, empathy, human dignity, and non-discrimination, ensuring that learners acquire the expected discipline for upright living.

Education as a Transformative Tool for Value Reorientation

A functional education does more than the conventional academic knowledge which transforms learners by shaping their attitudes, beliefs and behavior. To improve on this practice, education must be designed not only to transmit knowledge but also to foster civic virtues, moral reasoning and national consciousness, as well as deploy intentional transformative tools that not only communicate societal ideals but also internalize them through engaging, reflective, and experiential learning methods (Adepoju, 2021). When intentionally developed and effectively implemented, the curriculum can serve as a transformative tool that contributes to social regeneration and national development. The following are some of the most effective tools embedded within the educational framework:

- i. Value-Laden Subjects and Thematic Integration: Subjects like Civic Education, Social Studies, Religious Studies, Moral Instruction, Peace and Conflict Studies, and History are explicitly designed to transmit moral, civic, and national values. These subjects cover themes such as: Integrity and honesty; respect for laws and authority; tolerance and national unity;

human rights and social justice; and peace-building and conflict resolution. For example, Literature can highlight moral lessons from stories and characters while Science can promote values like honesty in research and environmental responsibility.

- ii. **Project-Based and Service Learning:** Service-learning and community-based projects offer students opportunities to apply learned values in real-life contexts. These activities encourage: Empathy and compassion through volunteerism; patriotism through national or environmental campaigns; responsibility through leadership in group projects; and respect and cooperation through teamwork. For example, a Civic Education project could involve students organizing a neighborhood clean-up, visiting orphanages, or hosting a town hall discussion on peaceful coexistence.
- iii. **Co-Curricular and Extra-Curricular Activities:** Programs such as: Debate and Literary Clubs; Drama and Cultural Societies; Peace Clubs and Human Rights Groups; School Assemblies and Moral Talk Sessions; and Scouting, Red Cross, and Man 'O' War ...provide non-formal platforms for reinforcing values such as discipline, teamwork, service, fairness, resilience, and respect. These activities give learners the chance to practice good citizenship, express moral perspectives, and take responsibility in social contexts.
- iv. **Use of Instructional Materials and Media:** Well-selected textbooks, storybooks, films, audio-visuals, and digital content are powerful in shaping values. For instance: Narratives of national heroes teach sacrifice and patriotism; Biographies of ethical leaders inspire integrity and courage; Moral stories and folktales offer context-relevant ethical lessons. Documentaries on human rights or environmental degradation provoke critical thinking and ethical reflection. When used intentionally, these materials promote emotional connection and moral imagination—key to lasting transformation.
- v. **Classroom Pedagogical Approaches:** The method of teaching is as important as the content. Transformative pedagogy encourages students to think deeply, challenge assumptions, and reflect on their actions. Some recommended strategies include:
 - Socratic questioning and guided discussions (developing critical thinking on moral issues);
 - Role play and dramatization (promoting empathy and ethical reasoning).
 - Case studies and dilemma analysis (applying values to real-life problems).
 - Reflective journaling (enhancing self-awareness and moral growth).
 - Collaborative learning (teaching respect, tolerance, and cooperation).These approaches move learners from rote memorization to personal conviction, which is key in reorienting behavior.
- vi. **Assessment of Affective and Moral Outcomes:** Value reorientation must be assessed, just like cognitive outcomes. Tools such as:
 1. Character report cards
 2. Peer and self-assessment on conduct
 3. Teacher observations and anecdotal records
 4. Portfolio assessments
 5. Classroom behavior rubrics

Education for Poverty Eradication and National Development

Poverty eradication in the world, especially in the less developed countries like Nigeria, has been of utmost concern to all governments. This has led to a lot of conferences seeking for strategies to proffer solution to this endemic problem. Some of such conferences are the World Education Forum held in April 2000, in Dakar-Senegal. In that conference, the international community underscored the need to eradicate extreme poverty and gave support to eliminate it through education. In another development, one of the virile outcomes of the World Summit for Social Development held in Copenhagen in 1995, was a commitment made to eradicate poverty.

In that same conference abject poverty was considered as a severe injustice and an abuse of human rights. The afore-mentioned conferences advocated for education as the right instrument of combating poverty. The reason being that education develops the human capital of a country thereby, aiding in poverty eradication. Education develops skills and knowledge in individuals thereby, enhancing the production capacity of its recipients more efficiently and effectively than the uneducated. Therefore, investment in education is not a waste but a solution for poverty eradication and a source of empowerment which reflects on economic growth. This has been the argument of the human capital theorist, Becker in Amie-Ogan (2012) stating that, education or training raises the productivity of workers by imparting useful knowledge and skills. This infers that education imparts relevant knowledge and skills with which level of production is raised in any meaningful engagement (work). Entrepreneurship education is education which seeks to provide students with knowledge, skills and motivation to encourage entrepreneurial success. Mohammed, et al, (2021) also conceptualized entrepreneurship education as education which aims at nurturing and equipping individuals with necessary skills and competencies, which affords them to be self-reliant and contribute positively to the society. The purpose of entrepreneurship education is to acquire skills and knowledge (the technical know-how) for self-reliance, job creation, and wealth creation. This connotes that school leavers do not need to scout around for jobs but to create jobs for themselves and others. In this way, they can meet their physiological, safety and belongingness need and contribute to the success of the society.

National development could be seen as the provision and creation of the conditions by which the citizens of a nation attain the fulfillment of their basic human needs. Here, attention is drawn on Maslow's position on the "hierarchy of needs" which includes both the lower order and higher order needs. There is however, the need for some caution here and this relates to the specific conditions and circumstances of the nation under discussion. For instance, in the developed societies of the world, national development would be seen in terms of systems-maintenance of achieved standards coupled with the necessary incremental additions.

In the third world societies like ours with our history and the various features of structural inhibitions and obstacles that exist, national development is as of necessity, transformative of systems. In such a context, national development would be seen as the qualitative and quantitative, positive and beneficial transformation of the lives of the people of a nation not only in terms of their economic activity and productivity, but also in terms of the existence of various institutions

and provisions that ensure the fulfillment of their other needs as human beings. Important aspects of such other needs would be individual and collective dignity, liberty and integrity. This national development process should also be autonomous, that is, it is informed by our indigenous needs and propelled by our indigenous forces and will. In the light of the above analysis of what national development is all about, what is important now is the re-education of the Nigerian and the consequent destruction of false consciousness in this matter. Thus, the Federal Government of Nigeria (2014) in recognition of the importance of character in the broad educational goals of its citizens incorporated character training through the National Policy on Education which states the broad educational goals to include:

- a) The inculcation of the right type of values and attitude for the survival of the individual and the Nigerian nation.
- b) The acquisition of appropriate skills and development of mental, physical and social abilities and competence to achieve these goals. The National Policy on Education (NPE, 2014) prescribed that the quality of instruction should include basic values among which are: i. Moral and spiritual principles in interpersonal and human relations, ii. Shared responsibility for the common good of the society, iii. Respect for the dignity of labour and promotion of emotional, physical and psychological health of all children.

Likewise, in this question of national progress, self-reliance, and development of an individual or nation, the Nigerian should be made to know that the key lies in the “thrill of creative effort”. Reinforcing Value Reorientation for National Development, material or otherwise, is not something spontaneous, not a gift from abroad or on a platter of gold but the result of creative effort and labour. Labour truly creative is consequently the main key to progress and national development. According to (UNESCO,2017) “it calls for initiative, patience, sacrifice, responsibility from Nigerians as from any other people”.

Recommendations

To effectively reposition the education as a transformative tool for national moral regeneration, the following strategic recommendations are proposed:

- i. Review Curriculum Frameworks to explicitly address national values across subjects.
- ii. Reinforce civic and moral education from primary through tertiary levels. There is an urgent need to prioritize and strengthen Civic and Moral Education as a foundational aspect of Nigeria’s education system.
- iii. Train teachers on value transmission methodologies. Teachers must be adequately prepared to effectively teach, model, and evaluate values within and beyond the classroom.
- iv. Promote ethical school culture through leadership, peer modeling, and reward systems. Schools must become incubators of ethical behavior, not just centers for academic instruction.
- v. Create national monitoring systems to track value-based academic delivery and learner outcomes.
- vi. Foster stakeholder collaboration and community engagement.

- vii. Establish school-based value and student-led committees.

Conclusion

The quest for national transformation in Nigeria must begin with the reorientation of values at every level of society—beginning with the educational system. In recent decades, the country has witnessed a steady erosion of moral standards, evident in rising incidents of corruption, youth restiveness, disrespect for authority, cultism, religious intolerance, and national disunity. These social problems are not merely political or economic failures; they are deeply rooted in the absence of consistent, value-based education and modeling from early childhood to adulthood.

This study has established that:

1. when carefully designed and deliberately implemented, education can instill core values such as integrity, civic responsibility, tolerance, and national unity among learners.
2. Furthermore, the implementation framework proposed in this study offers a practical roadmap for policymakers, educators, and community stakeholders to collectively reposition education toward national moral and value recovery.

Therefore, the value reorientation is a core national priority. If Nigeria is to rise above its present economic, moral and security crisis, value reorientation must be pursued deliberately through education to realize the vision of a just, united, peaceful, and prosperous nation. Education remains the tool for character formation and nation-building, it remains one of the most viable means of securing our dreamed Nigeria.

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